

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 7 OF 12

By the Bed

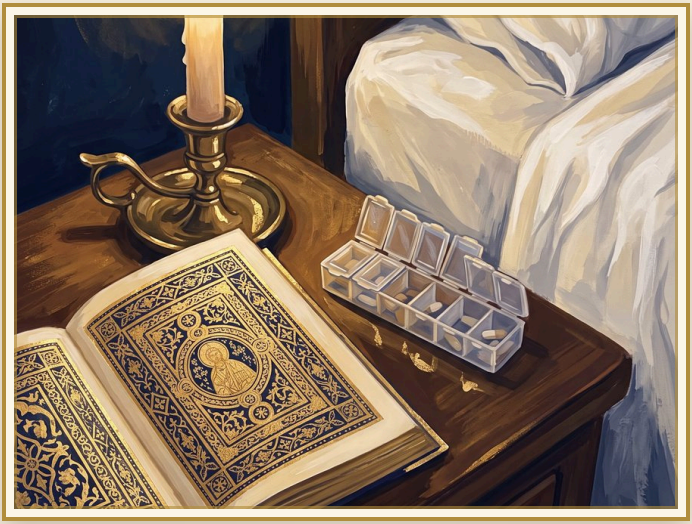
FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the body that is tired, the one who sits in the waiting room, and the one who keeps the vigil beside the bed.

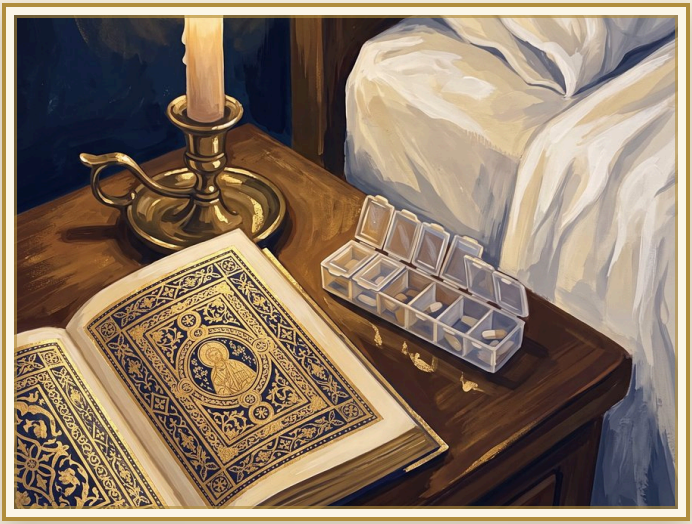


Father Lucas



BOOK 7

This book: The body, the doctors, the waiting, and the one who cares. Strength and company, and no promise of a cure.



How it goes: Week one is the body that remembers and the waiting room. Week two is the one who cares and the one who is cared for. Week three is asking for help, the anointing, sleep and laughter, with Day 200 in the middle. Week four is the cane, the limits, a hope that is not a promise, and the candle by the bed.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

Motto of the month: Held in the waiting.

Days: 184 to 214 (31 mornings)

Knot of the month: Health (and, along the way, peace and surrender)

Psalm of the month: 131. A quieted soul, like a child with its mother: the psalm for any waiting room.

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

This is the month we sit down. I won't pretend it's an easy one. Bodies get tired. Appointments pile up. And the chair by the bed can feel like the loneliest chair in the world. You are not a problem to be solved.

So I won't promise you a cure. No honest priest can. I'll promise what I can keep. Mary sits beside you in the waiting room. Your tired back counts as prayer. And the person who looks after you is held, too.

Take the pages slowly. Some mornings you'll only manage the prayer. That's plenty.

Put the kettle on. We have a month of waiting to do, and we'll do it together.

— Father Lucas

THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS

- **Week one:** the body that remembers, the calendar full of appointments, and Mary beside you in the waiting room.
- **Week two:** the caregiver and the patient: tired backs, long nights, kind nurses, and the chair by the bed.
- **Week three:** learning to ask for help, the anointing, sleep, and laughing again, with Day 200 in the middle.
- **Week four:** the cane, holy limits, hope without promises, a hand to hold, and the candle by the bed.

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

1. I will open the page before I open the news.
2. I will ask for one kind of help, out loud.
3. I will thank the hands that care for me, by name.

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WEEK 1

Week 1

DAYS 184 TO 190

This week: What the Body Remembers; The Appointment Calendar; Questions for the Doctor; Mary in the Waiting Room.



DAY 184

What the Body Remembers

In the same way, the Spirit also helps our weaknesses, for we don't know how to pray as we ought. But the Spirit himself makes intercession for us with groanings which can't be uttered.

ROMANS 8:26 (WEB)

The knee knows when it's going to rain before the radio does. Your back remembers the icy step from eleven winters ago. Your hands remember every cold morning at the sink. The body keeps a diary, and some days it reads you the whole thing out loud.

You've been talking over it for years. "I'm fine." "It's nothing." The body heard every one of those, and it kept writing.

So today we only listen. It isn't complaining. It's telling the truth, and prayer starts right there. Don't argue with it yet. Don't fix it. Let it finish its sentence.

Lord Jesus, you know this body better than I do. You know the knee, the back, and the hands that don't close all the way. I'm not here to argue with them today. I'm here to say I'm tired of carrying them alone. Stay in these bones. Give me strength for what the day asks, and patience for the slow parts, and a little humor for the stairs. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your chair for two minutes while the coffee cools. Say nothing. Notice where your body speaks up first, and let it.

☐ DONE

Where in my body have I stopped listening?

PSALM

38 — he hears the groaning you can't put into words; the psalm for a body that remembers.



DAY 185

The Appointment Calendar



Now, Lord, what do I wait for?
My hope is in you.

PSALM 39:7 (WEB)

Look at the calendar on your refrigerator. Half the squares now belong to somebody in a white coat. A lab on one date. A scan on another. A “return visit” with a question mark. It feels as if strangers are scheduling your life.

I kept a calendar like that for a year, when my own heart was acting up. Here’s what I learned. Every square is a place where someone will look up, say your name, and write it down.

Waiting isn’t empty time. It has people in it. Don’t read the squares as a verdict. Copy them out, one by one, and hand them over.

Lord, here are my appointments: the dates, the hours, and the long drives in between. I don't know what each visit will say. I do know who will be in the room before I get there. Walk the hallway ahead of me. Keep my hands steady on the clipboard. Make me patient with the line and kind to the person at the desk. Let me be gentle with myself in the car afterward. Amen.



TODAY

Take an index card. Write your next appointment, the time, and the office phone number. Tuck the card under your rosary or your Bible.

☐ DONE

What am I most afraid a white coat will tell me?

PSALM

39 — “Now, Lord, what do I wait for?”; the psalm for anyone with a calendar full of waiting.

186

DAY 186

Questions for the Doctor

Where there is no wise guidance, the nation falls, but in the multitude of counselors there is victory.

PROVERBS 11:14 (WEB)

Most of us think of the real question in the driveway. We're sitting in the car, annoyed at our own head. The doctor wasn't hiding anything. You froze. Everybody freezes in that little room, with the paper crinkling under them.

The old book says there's victory in many counselors. So ask. A good question isn't rude. It's respect, for the doctor and for your own life.

Write yours at the kitchen table, before the day gets loud. Keep them short. The truth hides in the short ones. And bring someone to listen. Two sets of ears hear more than one.

Lord Jesus, give me a clear head in that small room. Let me ask what I need to ask, and hear what is actually said. If the answer is hard, don't let me hear only the hard part. Hold my hand under the paper sheet. Give the doctor patience with me, and give me patience with the doctor. Let me not be ashamed to ask twice. Amen.



TODAY

Write three questions for your next visit, the shortest first. Begin with the one you're most afraid to ask. Keep the paper in your coat pocket.

☐ DONE

What do I really want to know, under all my other questions?

PSALM

41 — a prayer by the sickbed; he stays beside the one who is ill.

187

DAY 187

Mary in the Waiting Room

God, don't be far from me. My God, hurry to help me.

PSALM 71:12 (WEB)

Every waiting room has the same chairs. The same magazine from two years ago. A television nobody asked for. You sit with your coat on your knees and read the same page four times. The clock is louder in there than anywhere else.

Here's what I want you to know. After the worst day of her life, Mary sat in a small room with frightened friends, not knowing what came next. She didn't fill the silence with talk. She stayed.

She'll sit beside you on the plastic chair, close enough that you could lean.

Mary, soon I'll be sitting in a hard chair with my coat on my knees. Sit with me. When they call my name, let it be said gently. Keep my breathing slow. Keep my mind off the worst page of the worst book. Give me courage at the front desk, and a little patience with the clock on the wall. Let me not be alone in my own head. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, right where you are: “Mary, sit with me.” Say it again, slowly, the way you will in that chair. Practice it like a phone number.

☐ DONE

Who will I picture sitting beside me when they call my name?

PSALM

71 — “God, don’t be far from me”; the psalm for the long wait.



DAY 188

Pain Offered Is Not Wasted

who comforts us in all our affliction, that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, through the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.

2 CORINTHIANS 1:4 (WEB)

There's a kind of pain nobody should be told to be grateful for. I won't say it. I won't tell you it has a reason, or that it's a gift. It's pain. It hurts, and that's the end of that sentence.

But I've watched what happens to pain that's handed to God. It doesn't shrink. It changes address. It stops being only yours. The old folks in my parish call it offering it up. They don't mean pretending. They mean the ache gets carried by somebody besides you.

And the comfort you're given is meant to travel. Tonight it might reach one person. That's plenty.

Lord, this ache is mine, and I'm giving it to you. I'm not saying it's good. I'm saying I don't want it wasted. Take these hours of hurting and put them to work for someone more alone than I am. Give me relief where you can, and company where you can't. Teach me to hold it without hating it. Hold us both tonight. Amen.



TODAY

Think of one person who is also hurting. Say out loud: “Mary, take this ache, and use it for them.” Then let it go.

☐ DONE

Who is hurting today that my pain could somehow help carry?

PSALM

90 — “teach us to count our days”; the psalm for pain and the passing of time.



DAY 189

The Caregiver's Back

Return to your rest, my soul, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.

PSALM 116:7 (WEB)

If you take care of someone, your back is the first to know. It's the lifting and the turning, the leaning over a bed to tuck in a corner of sheet. A back doesn't give out from one big lift. It gives out from four hundred small ones. You counted them.

Marguerite sings in our choir. She carried her husband's weight for two long years. Last winter she told me, "Father, my voice is fine. It's my back that sings out of tune." We laughed. Then she cried. Then she went home to lift him.

Mary carried a child down a long road. She knows what a back can bear.

Lord Jesus, my back aches from loving this person. I'm not complaining. I'm telling you where it hurts. Put your hands where mine give out. Give me strength for the next lift, the next turn, the next night. And let me rest without feeling guilty. Bless the one I lift, and bless the lifting. Let someone notice I'm tired. Mary, rest with me. Amen.



TODAY

Stand up. Put both hands on the small of your back and lean slowly backward. Then say, “Thank you, back, for carrying us both.”

☐ DONE

What have I carried today that someone else could carry tomorrow?

PSALM

116 — “Return to your rest, my soul”; the psalm for the one who carries.

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Someone on your Names Page counts on you today. A knot that loosens in the morning can tighten by evening, for both of you. Open tomorrow’s page, and let someone carry you.



DAY 190

Tired in Every Bone



He gives power to the weak. He increases the strength of him who has no might.

ISAIAH 40:29 (WEB)

There's a tired that sleep doesn't touch. It lives in the bones and behind the eyes, and in the way you set the cup down. A nap won't fix it. A cheerful word won't fix it either.

So don't try to fix it today. Let me say one plain thing. God knows what tired is. He gives strength to the weak because he knew the weak would need it. Being weak isn't a failure of prayer. It's exactly where prayer lives.

Sit down. The dishes can wait. They've waited before, and they're good at it.

Father, I'm tired in places I didn't know I had. I can't tell what's the body and what's the worry. I'm not asking for a miracle this morning. I'm asking for enough: enough strength for the next hour, and enough kindness for whoever walks in. Carry what I can't. Let me sit down without shame. Thank you for the chair, the quiet, and this one minute. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Do nothing useful. Let the chair do the holding.

☐ DONE

What would I do today if I weren't so afraid of stopping?

PSALM

147 — he binds up the wounds; the psalm for a body worn thin.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 191 TO 197

This week: The Pill and the Psalm; When the News Is Hard; Leave the Search Till Morning; Good Hands in the Hospital.



DAY 191

The Pill and the Psalm

The LORD has heard my supplication. The LORD accepts my prayer.

PSALM 6:9 (WEB)

You know the pill box better than your own address. Seven little lids in a row. Morning, noon, night. For some it's a small chore. For others, every click of the lid says what's wrong.

Let it become a bell. The same three seconds you spend on the lid, spend on one sentence to God. Not instead of the doctor's plan. Beside it. The body gets what the doctor ordered, and the heart gets what Mary offers.

Nothing in the box changes. Only the hand that opens it. And that hand, I promise, is not alone.

Lord, thank you for the hands that made this medicine, and for the one who wrote my list. I take what I'm given with a quiet heart. Be in the glass of water and in the swallow. Be in the long hours between the lids. Keep my hands from shaking, or hold them if they do. Teach me to treat this small chore as a small prayer. Amen.



TODAY

Tuck a card with this line beside your pill box: “Lord, I give you this day.” Read it each time you open a lid. Change nothing else.

☐ DONE

What would change if I took every pill as a prayer?

PSALM

6 — “the LORD accepts my prayer”; the psalm for a weary body and a patient heart.

192

DAY 192

When the News Is Hard

As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people from this time forward and forever more.

PSALM 125:2 (WEB)

The phone rang, or the envelope came, or the doctor sat down instead of standing. You know the moment I mean. The room stays exactly the same, and everything in it is different.

Tom, my neighbor, got news like that last winter. He called me, and he didn't say a word. I sat on his back step until dark. Finally he said, "Well. Now I know." That was all. It was the start of getting through it.

You don't have to be brave. Mary isn't asking you to be strong. She's asking you not to be alone with it.

Our Lady, I've heard it, and I can't un-hear it. My hands are cold. The kitchen looks the same, and nothing is the same. I'm not asking you to change the words. I'm asking you to stand beside me while they sink in. Be the wall at my back. Let me cry if I need to. Give me one breath, and then one more. Amen.



TODAY

Look at a photograph of someone who would sit with you through this. Say today's prayer once more, slowly, to them and to Mary.

☐ DONE

Who should I tell first, and what will I say?

PSALM

125 — "the LORD surrounds his people"; the psalm for when the ground shakes.

193

DAY 193

Leave the Search Till Morning

Don't be afraid of sudden fear, neither of the desolation of the wicked, when it comes; for the LORD will be your confidence, and will keep your foot from being taken.

PROVERBS 3:25-26 (WEB)

It's late. The house is quiet. The little screen is bright in your hand, and you're typing the name of your trouble into it. Eleven minutes later you know a hundred things, and you're sure of none of them.

The screen doesn't know your body. It doesn't know your doctor's face, or your history, or what you ate. It only knows how to keep you scrolling. Your questions deserve a person, in daylight, who has your file.

Write the question down. Put it away. It'll keep. Morning is a better adviser than midnight.

Lord, it's late, and my mind wants to run down every road at once. I put the phone face down. I put my fear in your hands, where it can't grow in the dark. Tomorrow I'll ask a real person a real question. Tonight, hold the question for me. Let the dark be dark, and let that be enough. Give me rest. Amen.



TODAY

Write your worst question on a scrap of paper. Fold it, put it in a drawer, and leave it there for a week. Ask the doctor when the day comes.

☐ DONE

Which of my questions needs a person, and not a screen?

PSALM

30 — “the LORD, be my helper”; the psalm for the hour when worry gets loud.

194

DAY 194

Good Hands in the Hospital

Into your hand I commend my spirit. You redeem me, LORD, God of truth.

PSALM 31:5 (WEB)

A hospital is full of hands. Gloved hands, quick hands, hands that turn you and tuck you and write on the board by the door. After a while you start to feel like a thing being moved, and not a person.

You are still a person. Say your name to whoever touches you. Ask theirs. A name is a small door, and most people hold it open.

Then pray over the hands. Jesus laid his hands on the sick, and today he works through these ones, tired and sometimes careless as they are. Pray them kind. Pray them steady.

Lord Jesus, into your hand I place this body and this day. Bless the hands that will touch me: the ones that lift, the ones that write, the ones that only wait. Make them steady. Make them kind. Make me patient with them, and thankful. Tonight, when the lights go low, let me feel one more hand under all of theirs. Amen.



TODAY

Say a blessing over the hands that care for you, or for someone you love: “Lord, make these hands steady and kind.” Say it as if you could see them.

☐ DONE

Whose name did I learn this week, and whose should I ask?

PSALM

31 — “Into your hand I commend my spirit”; the psalm for putting yourself in good hands.



DAY 195

Thank the Nurses

Don't withhold good from those to whom it is due, when it is in the power of your hand to do it.

PROVERBS 3:27 (WEB)

Nurses carry more than they let on. Your chart, your fear, your daughter's fear on the phone, and four other rooms besides. They do it before their own coffee has gone cold.

Mrs. Doyle, who's cleaned our church for twenty years, once carried a thermos and a tin of shortbread to a night desk. Nobody asked her. "They don't eat," she said. "They just run." I'm told the tin stayed on that desk long after the shortbread was gone.

You don't need a tin. Learn the name on the badge and use it. Being called by name at three in the morning is its own small mercy.

Lord, bless the nurses and the aides who work while I sleep. Bless their feet, which hurt like mine. Bless the ones who are short with me because they've been up all night. Give them a moment of rest today, and let one kind word find them. Let me be that kind word, if I can. Amen.



TODAY

Thank the next person who helps you today. Look at the name tag, say the name, and say thank you. Mean it a little more than usual.

☐ DONE

Who held up my day this week without being thanked?

PSALM

39 — “Hear my prayer, the LORD”; a psalm of someone who needed to be heard.



DAY 196

The Body Is Not Your Enemy



Or don't you know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God? You are not your own,

1 CORINTHIANS 6:19 (WEB)

When something hurts for a long time, you start to feel at war. My knee betrayed me. My heart is failing me. We talk about our bodies the way we talk about a hired man who quit on us.

But your body never set out to hurt you. It has carried you through every day you can remember, up stairs, through funerals, across kitchens. It's the house where your prayers live. Scripture calls it a temple, even now. Even this tired.

Make peace with it today. Not a surrender. A truce. You can ask for help for a house and still love it.

Lord, I've been angry at this body. I've called it names under my breath. Forgive me. It has carried me a long way. Bless my legs, my hands, and the heart that keeps its stubborn time. Help me treat it as a gift, and not an enemy. Give it ease where it can have ease, and rest where it can't. Amen.



TODAY

Put one hand over the place that hurts most. Breathe in for four, out for six, three times. Then say, “You carried me. Thank you.”

☐ DONE

What would I say to my body if it were a tired friend?

PSALM

41 — he sustains the one who is ill; the psalm for making peace with a body that hurts.

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that wore you down is still out there. A peace you make with your body today can slip away by the end of the week. Open tomorrow’s page, and keep the truce.



DAY 197

A Walk to the Mailbox

I will walk before the LORD in the land of the living.

PSALM 116:9 (WEB)

It's not a long walk. Down the steps, along the path, to the box with the dented flag. Some days it feels like a mile. Some days you do it with one hand on the rail and your jaw set tight.

Walk it slowly anyway, as far as your doctor allows. You are walking in the land of the living, and the living are right there. A neighbor's dog. A bird on the wire. Somebody's laundry moving on a line.

Say nothing. Let the air touch your face. It's allowed to feel good for a minute, even now, even here.

Lord, thank you for the steps I can still take. Thank you for the rail, the path, and the little flag on the box. I don't know how far I'll walk next year, but I know where I'm walking today. Walk beside me. Keep my feet from hurry and my heart from fear. Let me notice one living thing and be glad of it. Amen.



TODAY

Walk to the mailbox slowly. Take your time on the steps. On the way, notice one living thing, and thank God for it by name.

☐ DONE

What living thing did I notice that I would have missed yesterday?

PSALM

71 — “I will always hope”; the psalm for a body that still walks.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 198 TO 204

This week: Eat as Though It Matters; The Sick One Beside You; Two Hundred Mornings; Machines in the Dark.

198

DAY 198

Eat as Though It Matters

The LORD's angel came again the second time, and touched him, and said, "Arise and eat, because the journey is too great for you."

1 KINGS 19:7 (WEB)

When you're sick, or looking after someone sick, the first thing to go is the table. Crackers over the sink. Cold toast at the counter. Coffee instead of supper. It seems like nothing. It isn't nothing.

Elijah once lay down under a bush and asked to die, he was so worn out. God didn't send a sermon. He sent an angel to touch him and say, "Get up and eat." Not "Pray harder." Eat.

Eating is not a luxury. It's part of the journey. Sit down. Use a real plate.

Lord, thank you for this plate, this fork, and this chair. I haven't been eating like someone who matters. Forgive me, and teach me again. Bless the food, and the hands that made it, and whoever is eating alone tonight. Give me the strength this meal was meant to give. Let it be a small feast for a tired body. Amen.



TODAY

Set one place at the table with a real plate and a napkin. Sit down, bless the food out loud, and eat slowly, with the television off.

☐ DONE

When did I last treat myself like someone worth feeding?

PSALM

90 — “Satisfy us in the morning”; the psalm for a body that needs feeding.



DAY 199

The Sick One Beside You

Ruth said, "Don't urge me to leave you, and to return from following you, for where you go, I will go; and where you stay, I will stay. Your people will be my people, and your God my God.

RUTH 1:16 (WEB)

Maybe you're the one in the bed. Maybe you're the one in the chair. Either way, there's another person in the room, and you've both gone quiet inside your own separate fear.

Eileen, in Scranton, spent one long winter beside her husband's bed. She told me the hardest part wasn't the nights. It was that they stopped telling each other things. "We both knew," she said, "and we were both so polite."

Where you go I will go, the old book says, and where you stay I will stay. Say the staying out loud.

Lord, bless the one who is sick beside me. Bless them in the bed or in the chair, whichever they are tonight. Give us the courage to say what we're both afraid to say. Give us some laughter, too, if you can spare it. Make us a little kinder to each other than we've been. Mary, hold us both. Amen.



TODAY

Add one name to your Names Page: the person beside you. Next to it, write the one thing you most want them to know.

☐ DONE

What have we both been too polite to say out loud?

PSALM

116 — “he has turned his ear to me”; the psalm for two people and one long illness.



DAY 200

Two Hundred Mornings

He counts the number of the stars. He calls them all by their names.

PSALM 147:4 (WEB)

Two hundred mornings. Stop a moment and let that number sit. Two hundred times you opened a page, read a few lines, and prayed in your own voice. Some mornings you did it tired. Some mornings you almost didn't.

I can't tell you everything that changed. Maybe nothing a doctor could write down. But people tell me the same small things. The house is quieter. The worst hour is shorter. A phone rang that hadn't rung in a long while. I promise nothing. I only tell you what I've heard.

He counts the stars and calls each one by name. He has yours.

Lord, thank you for two hundred mornings. Thank you for the ones I remember and the ones I don't. Thank you for Mary, who has never once complained about the hour. I'm still tired, and I'm still here. Keep calling me by name. Keep me coming back to the page. Let the knots I named stay loose. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and say the number out loud: “Two hundred.” Then say one name from your Names Page, and let the candle burn while you finish your coffee.

☐ DONE

What is a little looser now than it was a hundred mornings ago?

PSALM

147 — he calls the stars by name; the psalm for the day you were counted among them.

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let it slip once, right around the middle of a long stretch. I told myself I’d earned a rest. The knot noticed. It was tighter when I came back. Don’t stop at the halfway mark. Open tomorrow’s page.



DAY 201

Machines in the Dark



Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul, like a weaned child with his mother, like a weaned child is my soul within me.

PSALM 131:2 (WEB)

A hospital room at night is never dark. It has little green lights and little red ones. A machine hums, or beeps, or sighs like a refrigerator that wants attention. You lie there counting every sound.

Here's a trick. Let each beep be a bead. With each one, breathe a single word: "Mary." You turn the noise into a rosary the hospital never meant to give you.

A quieted soul is like a child on its mother's lap. It isn't silent because nothing is happening. It's silent because it's held. Let yourself be held.

Lord, the room is full of small sounds, and I can't turn them off. Let them be my beads tonight. Let every beep remind me that someone is watching over the one I love, or over me. Quiet my heart like a child on its mother's lap. If sleep is slow in coming, let me rest anyway, and let the one I love rest, too. Amen.



TODAY

When the room goes quiet tonight, breathe out the word “Mary” slowly, ten times. Pair each one with a small sound you hear.

☐ DONE

Which small sound could I turn into a prayer tonight?

PSALM

131 — a quieted soul, like a child with its mother; the psalm for the humming dark.



DAY 202

The Chair by the Bed



Then Jesus said to them, "My soul is exceedingly sorrowful, even to death. Stay here and watch with me."

MATTHEW 26:38 (WEB)

Every sickroom has a chair. It's never the good chair. It's the one from the kitchen, or the one with the broken arm, or the folding one someone found in a closet. Someone sits in it all night, and it leaves its mark on their back for a week.

Jesus asked his friends for something just as small. "Stay here and watch with me." That was all. He didn't ask them to fix anything. Remember Mary at the foot of the Cross, from Book 1. She stayed.

Your chair is holy. It's where love sits when it can do nothing else.

Lord Jesus, you asked your friends to stay awake with you, and they couldn't. I'll try, and sometimes I'll fail. Bless this chair and everyone who has ever sat in one like it. Make my staying a prayer, even when I can only sit. When my eyes close, send someone to watch over me. Mary, stay with me in this small, dim room. Amen.



TODAY

Clear the chair by the bed. Fold the blankets, set a small pillow on it, and rest your rosary or a holy card on the arm.

☐ DONE

Who has sat in a chair like this one for me?

PSALM

6 — “the LORD has heard the voice of my weeping”; the psalm for the long watch.



DAY 203

Letting Others Help



Hear, LORD, and have mercy on me. LORD, be my helper.

PSALM 30:10 (WEB)

Some of us were raised to say, "No, no, I'm fine." We said it for so many years that we forgot how to say anything else. Now there's a casserole at the door, a niece on the phone, a neighbor offering a ride, and we say no again.

Marguerite said it too, for months. Then her sister arrived with a suitcase and wouldn't leave. "I was so angry," Marguerite told me, "and then I slept." That's a holier thing than it sounds.

When someone asks what they can do, they're asking you for a gift. Be specific.

Lord, I've been proud about being strong. I don't want to be proud anymore. Send me the right person for one small thing today. Give me the words to ask, and the grace to say thank you without apologizing. Let the person who helps me feel that it was a gift to them. Teach me to receive, as well as to give, and to do it without counting. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person and ask for one specific help: a ride, an errand, an hour in the chair. Say it plainly, then say thank you.

☐ DONE

What have I refused to ask for, and called it pride?

PSALM

30 — “the LORD, be my helper”; the psalm for asking and being answered by a face.

DON’T LET IT TIE AGAIN

She never tires of you, but you can forget she’s there. Alone, the knot tightens quietly. Keep asking, for help and for her. Open tomorrow’s page, and tomorrow’s door.



DAY 204

Ask for the Anointing

> *Is any among you sick? Let him call for the elders of the assembly, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord;*
>
> JAMES 5:14 (WEB)

Many people think the Anointing of the Sick is only for the very end. That's an old mistake, and a sad one. It is for the seriously ill, and for the old and worn, and for anyone about to face a hard operation. It's a blessing of strength. It isn't a goodbye.

A priest prays over you, then touches your forehead and your hands with a little oil. That's all. The oil is plain. The love is not.

People tell me afterward that they felt less alone. I promise no cure, and neither does the Church. It offers peace, and company, and strength. Ask for it.

Lord Jesus, I want your touch, and I'm not too proud to ask for it. Send me a priest who will pray over me without hurry. Let the oil on my hands mean what it says: that I am yours, in strength and in weakness. Calm my fear of the word "anointing." Make it a gentle word for me. Amen.



TODAY

Call your parish office and ask one question: “How do I request the Anointing of the Sick, for me or someone I love?” Write down the answer.

☐ DONE

What am I afraid this blessing means, and what does it really mean?

PSALM

23 — “you anoint my head with oil”; the psalm that already knows the oil.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 205 TO 214

This week: Sleep Is a Mercy, Too; Laughing Again; The Cane Is Not Defeat; Limits Are Holy.



DAY 205

Sleep Is a Mercy, Too



For I have satiated the weary soul, and I have replenished every sorrowful soul." On this I awakened, and saw; and my sleep was sweet to me.

JEREMIAH 31:25-26 (WEB)

We were taught that rest is wages: you get it after the work is done. In a sickroom the work is never done. So you don't rest, your temper shortens, your memory goes soft, and everything hurts a little more.

The old prophet says, "I awakened, and saw; and my sleep was sweet to me." Sweet. Sleep isn't a prize. It's a present, and a present doesn't have to be earned.

Take it in pieces. Fifteen minutes with your shoes off isn't laziness. It's maintenance. Mary will mind the house while you do it. She's very good at it.

Lord, I'm so tired I can't tell my worry from my weariness. You give sleep to those you love. Give me a little today. Let it come easily, in the chair or on the couch or in the bed. Mind the one I care for while I rest. And when I wake, let me wake a little kinder. Amen.



TODAY

Lie down for four minutes with your hands open at your sides. No phone, no list. Let the day wait for you.

☐ DONE

What would I let go of if I truly believed rest was a gift?

PSALM

127 — “he gives sleep to his loved ones”; the psalm for the tired.

206

DAY 206

Laughing Again

Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with singing. Then they said among the nations, "the LORD has done great things for them."

PSALM 126:2 (WEB)

The first time you laugh in a sickroom, you feel guilty. You look around to see who heard. As if joy were rude. As if God had stepped out and left a sign on the door that said, “Be sad.”

He didn’t. A good laugh is a window, and the house needs air. I have seen a whole room change when one person told an old, silly story. The nurse laughed. The patient laughed hardest. Everyone breathed, and the room felt bigger afterward.

Laughing doesn’t mean you’ve stopped caring. It means you’ve remembered who you are.

Lord, thank you for laughter, for the sound of it in a house where it's been quiet. Forgive me when I think it's disrespect. Send me one small joke today, one old story, one silly face from a grandchild. Let me laugh without looking over my shoulder. Let the ones I love hear it, and take heart. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud the funniest thing anyone in your family ever said. Say it to someone, or to the empty kitchen. Let yourself laugh.

☐ DONE

Whose laugh do I miss most, and how did it sound?

PSALM

126 — “our mouth was filled with laughter”; the psalm of joy after tears.

207

DAY 207

The Cane Is Not Defeat

Don't reject me in my old age. Don't forsake me when my strength fails.

PSALM 71:9 (WEB)

Nobody wants the cane at first. It leans in the corner like an accusation. You go without it for weeks, holding on to walls and chairs, and you call that independence.

Walt ushered at our parish for thirty years. He held his cane like a snake for a month. Then one morning he used it, and I watched him come up the church steps standing straight. "Father," he said, "it's a third leg that never talks back."

The shepherd's psalm has a rod and a staff, and nobody calls that defeat.

Lord, I take this cane out of the corner and make peace with it. It's not an insult. It's a friend that doesn't talk. Bless the rubber foot and the worn handle. Bless the hand that grips it. Keep my steps from falling, and keep my pride from tripping me. Walk with me, down the hall and out the door, and into the long afternoon. Amen.



TODAY

Take your cane, or the back of a chair, in both hands. Stand tall for ten seconds. Say, "Thank you for holding me up."

☐ DONE

What help have I been calling weakness, when it was wisdom?

PSALM

71 — "Don't forsake me when my strength fails"; the psalm for a body that needs a third leg.



DAY 208

Limits Are Holy

He said to them, "Come away into a deserted place, and rest awhile." For there were many coming and going, and they had no leisure so much as to eat.

MARK 6:31 (WEB)

There comes a night when the caregiver says, “I can’t.” It feels like a sin. It feels like walking out of church in the middle of the service.

Jesus said to his tired friends, “Come away and rest awhile.” Not “Do more.” Not “Be stronger.” He knew they were worn out, and he knew the crowds were still coming. Rest wasn’t a break from the work. It was part of the work.

A limit isn’t the end of love. It’s the shape love takes in a human body. Stand at yours without shame.

Lord, I can't do it all, and I'm tired of pretending. Show me where my limit is, and give me the courage to stand at it without shame. Send help to the places I can't reach. Bless the one I care for, and bless the hour when I put the work down. Teach me to rest as an act of love. Amen.



TODAY

Decide on one thing you will not do today, and say aloud, "That is enough." Then cross it off the list.

☐ DONE

What do I keep doing that someone else could do just as well?

PSALM

90 — "teach us to count our days"; the psalm for knowing how much one person can carry.



DAY 209

Pray for Your Doctor

I exhort therefore, first of all, that petitions, prayers, intercessions, and givings of thanks be made for all men,

1 TIMOTHY 2:1 (WEB)

Your doctor goes home with your name somewhere in the back of their mind. They have a kitchen too, and a bad back, and a mother who's getting older. Some days they carry hard news in the car like a stone in a coat pocket.

We pray for the priest, and the sick, and the people we love. Hardly ever for the one in the white coat. Yet they work with half the facts, on a clock, and they're still expected to be kind.

A doctor who's been prayed for walks into the next room a little lighter. They'll never know why. You will.

Lord, bless my doctor. Give them a clear mind, a gentle voice, and the patience to listen when I ramble. Rest their eyes at the end of the day. When they have to say a hard thing, give them the right words. When there's good news, let them feel it. Bless their family, and let them sleep. Amen.



TODAY

Say your doctor's name aloud with this short prayer: "Lord, give them clear eyes and a rested heart." Say it once more at bedtime.

☐ DONE

What would I want someone to pray for me if I did their work?

PSALM

116 — "What will I give to the LORD for all his benefits?"; the psalm of thanks for those who help.



DAY 210

A Good Day Counts

Satisfy us in the morning with your loving kindness, that we may rejoice and be glad all our days.

PSALM 90:14 (WEB)

When you're sick, the good days come like company you didn't expect. You're sure they won't stay, so you spend the whole day listening for the knock. Or you feel guilty enjoying it, because somebody you love isn't having one.

Let a good day be a good day. It doesn't owe tomorrow anything. The psalm asks for gladness in the morning, and then adds "all our days." The good ones too.

Write it down tonight. Memory is thin, and in a hard week you'll want this page in your hand.

Lord, thank you for a day that went all right. Thank you for the cup that stayed warm, the call that came, the pain that stayed quiet for an hour. I won't wait for the other shoe to drop. I'll enjoy this shoe. Let today be a lamp in a harder week. Make me grateful, and not guilty. Amen.



TODAY

Write today's date and one thing that went all right yesterday. Keep the page in the drawer with your pen, and add to it when you can.

☐ DONE

What small good thing did I almost not notice this week?

PSALM

147 — "Sing to the LORD with thanksgiving"; the psalm for a day worth keeping.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A page you skip once is easy to skip twice. Good days are exactly when we forget to pray. Open the page on the easy mornings, so you know where it is on the hard ones.

211

DAY 211

Hope Is Not a Promise

But if we hope for that which we don't see, we wait for it with patience.

ROMANS 8:25 (WEB)

Let me be careful here. I can't tell you the test will come back clear, or that the pain will lift by next month. I won't say it. No honest person can.

Hope is something smaller and stronger. It's the plant on the windowsill that bends toward the light, though it can't see the sun. Saint Paul says we wait for what we can't see with patience, and he doesn't say it's easy.

Hope doesn't say, "It will be fine." It says, "I'm not alone, whatever it is." That is a smaller promise, and a truer one. Today, wait well, and wait with her.

Lord, I don't know how this will go. I'm not asking you to tell me. I'm asking you to be here, whichever way it goes. Plant in me a hope that doesn't need a guarantee. Let me lean toward you the way a plant leans toward a window. Give me patience for the waiting, and company for the dark. Amen.



TODAY

Stand at a window for one minute, with your phone in another room. Find one living thing that leans toward the light.

☐ DONE

What is hope for me today, if it isn't a promise?

PSALM

6 — "the LORD accepts my prayer"; a psalm that asks and waits without a guarantee.



DAY 212

A Hand to Hold

For I, the LORD your God,
will hold your right hand,
saying to you, 'Don't be afraid.
I will help you.'

ISAIAH 41:13 (WEB)

The oldest comfort we have is a hand. Before we had words, we had a thumb to hold. At the very end, nurses tell me, people still reach for one.

God uses the same picture. “I will hold your right hand,” he says. He doesn’t say, “I will give you advice.” Hand to hand, the way a grandfather holds a child at the curb.

Mary held a small hand for years. She knows how it feels when a hand lets go too early, and how it feels when it stays. Whose hand will you hold today? If no one is near, hold your own.

Lord, I'm reaching for you in the dark with one hand, and for someone near me with the other. Let both be found. Hold my right hand on the days I can't tell whether I'm afraid or only cold. Hold theirs. Let this small touch carry what neither of us can say, and let it be enough for tonight. Amen.



TODAY

Take someone's hand and hold it for one full minute without speaking. If you're alone, hold your own left hand in your right.

☐ DONE

Whose hand held mine when I was most afraid?

PSALM

30 — "you have turned my mourning into dancing"; the psalm for being held through the dark.



DAY 213

The Body's Thank-You

I will give thanks to you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Your works are wonderful. My soul knows that very well.

PSALM 139:14 (WEB)

All month we've been asking things of the body. Heal. Hold. Carry. Behave. Today let's thank it, plainly, once, like a neighbor who's helped for years and never been told.

Thank the heart for beating at three in the morning while you weren't paying attention. Thank the lungs for twenty thousand breaths a day that you never once counted. Thank the eyes reading this page. Even the hands that shake.

The psalmist says "fearfully and wonderfully made," and he says it from a place of pain. Thanks doesn't fix the ache. It changes who's standing there with it.

Lord, I thank you for this body, which you made and which I've taken for granted. Thank you for the heart, the hands, the lungs, and the stubborn feet. Thank you for the parts that still work, and for the parts that have taught me patience. I give it back to you today, gently, with thanks. Amen.



TODAY

Thank three parts of your body by name, out loud. Start with the one that gives you the most trouble.

☐ DONE

Which part of my body has served me longest without a thank-you?

PSALM

139 — “I am fearfully and wonderfully made”; the psalm that thanks the body.



DAY 214

The Candle by the Bed



For I hope in you, the LORD.
You will answer, Lord my God.

PSALM 38:15 (WEB)

Here we are at the end of the month. You've sat in the waiting room, filled in the forms, and made peace with the cane and the pill box. You've been brave in a hundred small ways nobody saw.

Father Jakob, long ago in Augsburg, lit a candle by the bed of every sick person he visited. He said it was so they would never be completely in the dark. When he left, the candle stayed. Tonight you do the same: leave something burning.

If there's oxygen in the house, use a battery candle. The light is what matters, not the flame.

Lord Jesus, I light this for the one who needs light, and for the one who needs it most, which may be me. Be in the small flame by the bed. Be in the long hours and the short ones. Keep us company in this room, and in the waiting that isn't over. Mary, Undoer of Knots, hold the thread we can't hold. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle, or a battery one, near the bed. Read one name from your Names Page aloud. Let it burn while you finish your coffee.

☐ DONE

What light do I want to leave burning for the next person?

PSALM

38 — "I hope in you; you will answer"; the psalm that opens and closes this month's waiting.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A knot undone can tie again if you skip a few mornings. If you slip, don't scold yourself. Come back the very next day, as if nothing happened. Mary never counted the days you missed.

LOOKING BACK AT BOOK 7

☐ Where did I feel Mary closest this month, and in which room?

☐ What did I finally ask for help with, and who said yes?

☐ What did my body tell me that I was ready to hear?

☐ Which name on my Names Page do I carry into next month?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS, TO CLOSE THE MONTH

My friend,

You made it through the waiting room. It wasn't a month of answers, and I told you it wouldn't be. But look at what you did. You wrote your questions down. You thanked a nurse. You let someone help. You said the number of your mornings out loud.

The knot of the body isn't mine to untie, and it isn't yours. It is God's, in his time and his way. What you can do is keep it from tightening in the dark. Company does that. A prayer at the bedside does that.

It can tie again. A new test, a bad night, a long week. When it does, open the page. She'll be in the chair.

— Father Lucas

THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS · BOOK 7 · THE WAITING ROOM

Date:

THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: BY THE BED

Light a candle near the bed or your favorite chair. A battery candle is just as good.

Say the names on your Names Page, one at a time, and after each name say: "Mary, stay close."

Blow it out with an “Amen,” and leave the chair where it is.

NOTES

What changed this month:

Names to add:

BACK COVER

“Waiting is not empty time. It is time with someone in it.” — Father Lucas

Turn to Book 8 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 7 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 8 · TWO FLAMES